



MINDFULNESS ON THE MATS™

Yips Protocol

The Combat Recovery System

Performance Recovery Under Pressure

A repeatable system for preventing and recovering from
performance breakdowns — on and off the mat.

Program Overview & Mission

Mission: To equip martial arts students with a repeatable system for preventing and recovering from performance breakdowns under pressure — in competition, at school, at work, and in everyday life.

Program Detail	Specification
Target Audience	Martial arts students, competitors, and performance athletes
Format	Standalone protocol — integrates into existing MOTM™ curriculum
Primary Use	Competitions, belt tests, high-stakes training
Core Framework	The 4-Step Combat Reset — an in-the-moment recovery sequence

IMPORTANT DISCLAIMER

This is NOT therapy. This protocol is designed for performance skills training and does not replace professional mental health counseling. If a student shows signs of clinical anxiety, refer them to a licensed mental health professional.

SECTION 1 · THE "COMBAT RESET" FRAMEWORK

Section 1: The "Combat Reset" Framework

The yips happen when a student's attention shifts from the movement to the outcome. They start thinking instead of doing — and the body tightens up. The goal of this protocol is to give students a repeatable physical sequence they can use instantly when things go wrong. We don't train to avoid mistakes. We train how to handle them when they happen.

The 4-Step In-the-Moment Reset

1**Catch It (Recognize)**

Acknowledge the "glitch" without judging it.

"That just happened. Eyes forward."

2**Clear It (Exhale / Soften)**

Use a Kiai-style breath — drop the shoulders, dump the air.

"Drop it. Breathe out."

3**Coach It (Encourage)**

Use a short, direct self-compassion cue.

"Stay in it. Next move."

4**Commit (Target)**

Lock onto the very next physical requirement.

"Find the target."

"

We don't train to avoid mistakes — we train how to handle them.

SECTION 2 · BREATH TECHNIQUES

Section 2: Breath Techniques

When pressure spikes, breath is the fastest tool available. These two techniques cover opposite ends of a performance: one to use before stepping onto the mat, and one to fire in the middle of active movement.

The Physiological Sigh — Pre-Performance

Use this before stepping onto the mat or between rounds.

- 1 Take a full inhale through the nose
- 2 Follow with a second, shorter “top-off” inhale to fully expand the lungs
- 3 Long, slow exhale through the mouth until the lungs are completely empty
- 4 Repeat 1–3 times

Why it works: The double inhale re-opens tiny air sacs in the lungs that collapse under stress. The long exhale activates the body’s natural calm-down response. Students feel the shift in one or two cycles. Teach it before they need it.

The Power Exhale — Mid-Performance

Use this during active movement — this is Step 2 of the Combat Reset.

- 1 A quick, sharp, forceful breath out — Kiai-style hiss or “tsh” sound
- 2 Simultaneously drop the shoulders and unclench the hands
- 3 Immediately redirect attention to the next movement

Why it works: A forceful exhale immediately resets the diaphragm and releases the stiffness and tension that builds when a student is fighting their own body. It’s the fastest physical reset available in motion.

SECTION 3 · WHY WE TRAIN MISTAKES

Section 3: Why We Train Mistakes

A common question is: Why practice making a mistake? In the MOTM™ framework, we don’t practice failure — we practice Recovery.

Inhibitory Learning	Purposely making a mistake in a safe environment teaches the brain that a “glitch” is not a catastrophe. This prevents the fight-or-flight response that causes the yips.
Decoupling Anxiety	By choosing when to make a mistake, the student remains the “pilot.” This breaks the association between making a mistake and feeling shame or panic.
The Recovery Habit	The bad habit in competition isn’t the mistake — it’s the 2-second freeze that follows it. These drills automate the Combat Reset so the student recovers before they even have time to think.

SECTION 4 · TRAINING PROTOCOLS

Section 4: Training Protocols

The Intentional Glitch Drill

#	What Happens	Instructor Note
1	The Intentional Mistake: During a Kata/form or fighting/grappling drill, the instructor calls out “Reset!” It is just as important to train the recovery when a mistake is made in a fight as it is during a form.	Use a calm, clear voice. This is a drill command, not a correction.
2	The Response: The student immediately introduces a deliberate fumble or pause, executes the 4-Step Combat Reset, and continues without restarting the sequence.	Make every effort to not allow restarts. The value of this drill is in continuing — not in the sequence being clean.
3	What Success Looks Like: A successful rep in this drill isn’t a clean form — it’s a fast, automatic recovery after the mistake.	Praise the speed of the reset out loud. “That recovery — that’s the skill.”

SECTION 5 · THE “INSTRUCTOR VOICE” (SELF-COMPASSION)

Section 5: The “Instructor Voice” (Self-Compassion)

What a student says to themselves after a mistake determines whether they recover or spiral. Teach them to use the same voice they would use to coach a younger student — kind, firm, and forward-focused.

Step	What to Say	Why It Works
Normalize	"Shake it off. Even the greats have glitches."	Stops the shame spiral before it starts. Keeps the student in the moment.
Humanize	"This is a high-pressure moment. It's okay to feel this. Everyone does."	Reminds them they're not broken. This is what pressure does to everyone.
Encourage	"I've got the tools. Next move. Finish the fight."	Short and forward-only. Pulls focus off the mistake and onto what's next.

For Students Who Also Teach or Coach:

This works especially well for junior instructors and assistant instructors. Ask them to picture another student they coach — a white belt, a newer member — who just made this exact same mistake in front of everyone.

Instructor Self-Compassion Prompt

- Picture another student you coach. They just made this same mistake.
- What would you say to them right now? Say that to yourself.
- "Would I tell them they're a failure? No. So why am I saying that to myself?"
- Use the same voice you'd use on the mat — kind, firm, and forward-focused.

SECTION 6 · IDENTITY REINFORCEMENT

Section 6: Identity Reinforcement

What you say on the mat becomes what students say to themselves when you're not there. Every time a student resets and keeps going, they're building the identity of someone who doesn't fold under pressure. Use these cues consistently — and say them out loud.

Situation	What to Say
After a successful reset	"That recovery right there — that is the actual skill we are training."
During a drill	"If it happens, show me your reset."
On the mindset	"Champions aren't the ones who don't make mistakes. They're the ones who recover fastest."
Closing a session	"Train the recovery, not just the performance."

Identity Statement

“I am someone who recovers under pressure.”

Have students say this out loud after every successful reset drill. Repetition of recovery — not just performance — is what builds a resilient identity. That’s the real black belt.

© 2026 Dr. Joseph Assouline, PsyD | Mindfulness on the Mats™ | Yips Protocol | For Instructor Use Only